

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN BOSNIA AND HERZEGOVINA

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action shapes what happens to the rivers and land of Bosnia and Herzegovina, and one small village showed the country exactly how far a determined community will go to protect its water. In the summer of 2017, in the village of **Kruščica** in central Bosnia, an investor arrived with machines and a police escort to build two small hydropower plants on the little river that is the village's drinking water. The villagers blocked the bridge to the construction site. And then they did not leave. Women took the lead, keeping watch from a wooden hut beside the bridge, day and night, in shifts, through the seasons — and when riot police came at dawn and cleared them by force, injuring and arresting them, they came back and stood guard again. For more than five hundred days and nights, the **Brave Women of Kruščica** held that bridge. Alongside the blockade, they took the permits to court, and won: the environmental permit was annulled, and then, in December 2018, a court struck down the dam permits for lack of proper consultation with the community. Only then did the women leave the bridge. Two dams were stopped by a village that refused to move. The details are worth setting down, because they show how a fight like this is actually won. The two plants, Kruščica 1 and Kruščica 2, were small hydropower projects of the kind that has spread across the Balkans in the thousands, driven by subsidies that make them profitable for their investors whatever the cost to the river. The blockade began in August 2017, when the machines first arrived, and the villagers organised a round-the-clock watch from a hut beside the bridge; a week later, at dawn, riot police cleared them by force, and women who had stood peacefully on the bridge were hurt, detained, and fined. They did not stop. A year on, when the investor tried again with police protection, some two hundred villagers turned the machines back once more. And through it all, in parallel, they fought the permits in court, until the court struck them down.

The Kruščica story teaches two things about defending rivers and land here — including its hard limits, which this guide states from the outset. The first is the pattern that runs through every guide: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever — the affected community, the documentation, the coalition, the legal challenge, and the country's and the world's attention — pressed together. The second is distinctly Bosnian, and it was born on a bridge. **A determined community, standing physically in the way and taking the flawed permits to court, backed by international solidarity, can stop a project even against connected investors and weak institutions.** That power — the sustained blockade, the court challenge to a defective permit, the wider river-defence movement, and the outside attention that amplifies a small village's stand — is Bosnia's distinctive lever, and this guide is built around it. It is worth naming what made the Kruščica stand work as a model, because it is instructive. It was rooted in the whole community but led visibly by its women, who took the daytime watch while the men took the nights, so that the burden was shared and no single person could be picked off or worn down alone. It paired the physical blockade, which bought time by keeping the machines out, with a patient legal challenge, which turned that time into a permanent win. And it drew in a wider movement and an international audience that a lone village could never have commanded, so that a fight over one small river became a cause watched across Europe. That combination — a shared and sustainable stand, a parallel legal case, and a reach far beyond the village — is the template.

But the same story carries honest warnings, and this guide will not hide them. The Kruščica win took an **extraordinary, sustained sacrifice** — five hundred days on a bridge, police violence, injuries, arrests, fines, and icy winters — that not every community can give. The victory came from the blockade **and** the court together, and even then the investor could **reapply**, so the villagers stayed vigilant. And it was won in a country of **fragmented, post-war governance** — split among entities and cantons, with weak institutions and a small-hydropower boom driven by subsidies that enrich connected investors — where the system is often tilted against the community. It is worth being honest about how much that sacrifice asked of ordinary people. Holding a bridge around the clock for more than five hundred days means standing watch through freezing nights, leaving work and family to take a shift, facing down police and hired men, and enduring the slow grind of a fight with no certain end — and it was borne largely by villagers, many of them women with households to run, who simply decided that their water was worth it. A guide can teach the method, but it should not pretend the method is easy; the Kruščica win was extraordinary precisely because the sacrifice behind it was. This guide is written with both truths in view: the real, distinctive power of a community that stands in the way and litigates, amplified by solidarity — and the sacrifice, the vigilance, and the tilted, fragmented system that qualify it.

Most communities do not know HOW to make that power effective. They face a concession or a project and assume "the investor and the authorities have decided and nothing can be done," and never organise, never document, never challenge the permit, never reach the wider movement or the world. They generate private loss without a public claim.

The gap between a community that holds its river and one that loses it is rarely courage — the women of Kruščica showed courage beyond measure. It is method: knowing how to organise, document, blockade wisely, challenge the flawed permit, and draw in the movement and the world.

This guide shows what actually works — inside the Bosnian system as it is.

The Strategic Framework

Effective campaigns follow the same underlying pattern, whether the goal is to stop a hydropower plant, a mine, or another destructive project:

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STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION (find the decision, the permit, and the leverage)
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STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION (build proof of the harm and the flawed permit)
|
STEP 3: LOCAL OPPOSITION (organise the community and hold the ground)
|
STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES (the permit, the consultation, and the courts)
|
STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY (make it national and international)
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These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. Documentation feeds the legal case and the public argument at once; the community holds the ground; a court filing or a blockade is a headline and a headline draws in the movement and the world. The community that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, is the one that wins — a permit quashed, a project halted, a river held. The Brave Women of Kruščica did exactly this — they held the bridge, documented the threat, challenged the permits, and drew the nation and the world to their little river.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Bosnia's give communities a distinctive set:

- **The physical blockade.** A community that **stands in the way** — as Kruščica held its bridge — can physically stop construction while it fights, a proven and powerful lever. This is the lever that most distinguishes the Bosnian repertoire, and its logic is simple but powerful: a hydropower project cannot be built if the machines cannot reach the site, and a community that controls the single access route — a bridge, a track, a narrow valley road — can keep them out with nothing more than its own presence. The blockade does not by itself win the legal fight, but it does something just as important: it stops the irreversible damage while the slower levers, the courts and the movement, do their work, so that the community is not left arguing over a river that has already been destroyed.
- **The consultation-defective permit.** Bosnia's small-hydropower permits are often granted **without proper community consultation** or on flawed assessments — a real legal weakness a court can strike down. This is the other side of the Bosnian coin, and it pairs naturally with the blockade: the same haste and clientelism that push these projects through tend to skip the consultation and the careful assessment the law requires, leaving the permit legally vulnerable. A community that can prove it was never properly consulted, or that the environmental assessment ignored real harm, hands a court a clear and lawful reason to annul the permit — which is exactly what happened at Kruščica, where the decisive court ruling turned on the failure to consult the community whose water was at stake.
- **The courts.** Bosnia's **courts**, cantonal and higher, can and do **annul flawed permits**, as they did at Kruščica.
- **The river-defence movement.** The **Blue Heart of Europe** campaign and its partners give a local fight a **regional movement, expertise, and solidarity**.
- **International attention.** **International media and solidarity** can amplify a small village's stand and pressure the authorities, as they did for Kruščica.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers easily stop projects. Kruščica took a **staggering, sustained sacrifice**. The court win could be **reopened** by a fresh application. And Bosnia's **fragmented, clientelist system** favours connected investors. This guide takes those limits seriously, names them plainly, and shows you how to fight anyway — organising the community, holding the ground where you must, challenging the flawed permit, and drawing in the movement and the world, as Kruščica drew them in.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see. Before you spend a single week, map who actually decides your project's fate, at which level, and where along that path the decision — or the leverage — is weakest.

The Levels of Decision

A Bosnian development or hydropower project runs through several tracks at once, and each is a place to intervene — and Bosnia's fragmented, post-war structure means you must know exactly which level decides.

The cantons and entities. Bosnia is divided into **two entities** — the Federation (itself split into **cantons**) and Republika Srpska — plus the Brčko District, and much power over permits and concessions sits at the **cantonal or entity level**, not the state. Know which authority granted your project's permit, as Kruščica's was a cantonal matter. Getting this right at the outset is not a technicality but a strategic necessity, because in Bosnia's layered structure the power to grant, and to annul, a concession or permit may sit with a cantonal ministry, an entity body, or a municipal authority, and a campaign that petitions or sues the wrong level wastes precious time. Establish early, ideally with legal help, exactly which authority issued each document your project depends on, because that tells you which office to pressure, which record to demand, and which court has the power to strike the permit down.

The concession and the permit. A hydropower or development project runs on a **concession** and an **environmental and construction permit**, often granted with little consultation — the documents where the project is most vulnerable.

The investor. **Private investors**, foreign and domestic, build the projects, drawn by **subsidies** that make small hydropower profitable regardless of the harm.

The courts. Bosnia's **courts** — cantonal, entity, and higher — can **annul flawed permits**, as the Novi Travnik court did for Kruščica.

The community and the movement. The **organised community, the river-defence movement, and international solidarity** are the force that documents, blockades, litigates, and draws attention — the level that won at Kruščica.

The Journey of a Project

A typical project moves from a **concession** and an **environmental and construction permit** granted by a cantonal or entity authority, through the **investor** who builds it, toward construction — with the **community, the courts, the movement, and the world** able to blockade, document, and litigate at any point. **Every one of those stages is a door you can put your foot in.** The distinctive Bosnian doors are the **physical blockade** that halts construction, the **court challenge to a consultation-defective permit**, and the **movement and international attention** that amplify the fight. Find out exactly where your project stands, and, crucially, **which authority granted the permit, whether the community was properly consulted, and whether the permit is flawed**, because those are often where a project can be stopped.

Follow the Project, the Permit, and the Consultation

Behind a project stand a proponent — an investor, sometimes with connected backing — and the authorities who granted the permit. Trace who profits, who decided, and — critically in Bosnia — **whether the community was consulted, whether the environmental permit is sound, what subsidies drive the project, and what it does to the river, the water, and the community.** Two questions unlock most Bosnian fights: **Was the community properly consulted, and is the permit lawful?** and **Can the community hold the ground and draw in the movement and the world while it fights?** The flawed permit and the community's stand are, together, the heart of most Bosnian campaigns. The two work in tandem in a way particular to these fights: the community's stand buys the time and creates the pressure, while the flawed permit gives the courts the lawful reason to end the project for good. A blockade alone can be worn down or cleared and leaves the permit standing, ready for the machines to return; a court case alone can grind on for years while the river is dug up. Pressed together, as at Kruščica, they cover each other's weaknesses — the stand holds the ground until the court delivers, and the court makes the ground held permanent.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies and forces that can check the deciders, because they are levers too. The **courts**, which do annul flawed permits; the **environmental and consultation law**, weak but real; the **river-defence movement** — the Blue Heart campaign and its Bosnian partners; the **independent press**; the **international organisations and solidarity networks**; and the **organised community** itself, which holds the ground. In Bosnia, the **community's physical stand and the court challenge**, amplified by the **movement and international attention**, are the most distinctive and decisive levers. Each is a separate front, and a project with a flawed, unconsulted permit, a community physically in its way, and a court and a movement against it rarely proceeds untouched — as the Kruščica dams did not. You do not have to choose one front: the same proof of the missing consultation and the harm can go to the courts, the movement, the

press, and the world at once, and each front that opens strengthens the others and helps sustain the community’s stand. A Bosnian campaign’s power comes not from any single lever but from pressing several together — the community holding the ground, the courts striking down the flawed permit, and the movement and the world amplifying it all — so that a small village fights with a reach and a resilience far beyond its size, as Kruščica did.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit months of effort, calibrate honestly. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how Bosnian and comparable campaigns tend to go, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the **community can hold the ground**, whether the **permit was granted without consultation** or on a flawed assessment, whether the **courts** can be engaged, whether the **river-defence movement** joins, and whether **international attention** can be drawn. Where the community can stand firm and the permit is flawed, Bosnia's levers are real, as Kruščica showed; but temper every figure with the honest knowledge that the Kruščica blockade took over five hundred days, that the win could be reopened, and that the fragmented system favours connected investors.

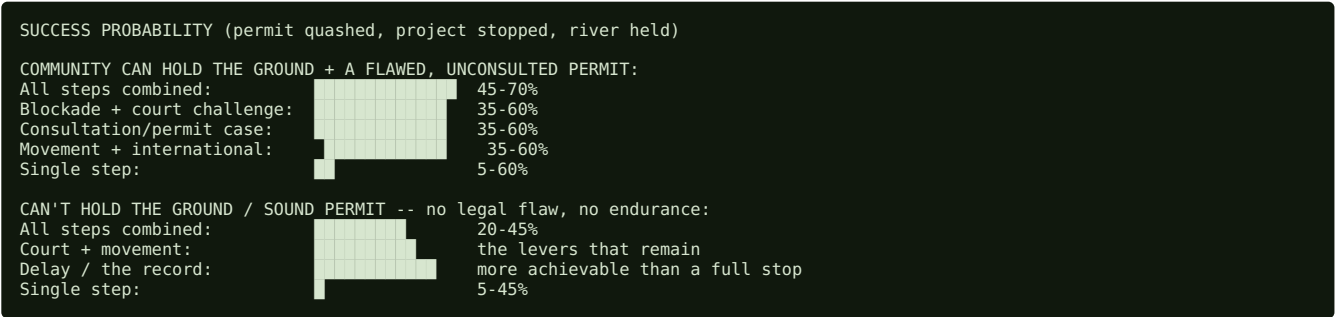
Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	5-10%	weeks-months	low	Basis for every other step
Physical blockade	35-60%	weeks-months+	low money / high effort	Construction halted while you fight
Consultation / permit challenge	35-60%	months-years	low-moderate	The permit annulled; the project halted
Court challenge	30-55%	1-3 years	low-moderate	A flawed permit quashed; delay
Community organisation	40-65%	ongoing	low	A community that can hold and litigate
River-defence movement	35-60%	ongoing	low	Expertise, solidarity, and reach
International attention	35-60%	ongoing	low	Pressure that amplifies the fight
Media & national attention	35-60%	ongoing	low	The nation engaged
All steps (community holds + flawed permit)	45-70%	months-years	low-moderate	Permit quashed; project stopped
All steps (can't hold / sound permit)	20-45%	months-years	low-moderate	Delay; the record; partial

Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and Bosnia's real strengths are distinctive — the **physical blockade**, the **consultation-defective permit challenge**, the **courts**, the **river-defence movement**, and **international attention**. Its constraints are specific: the blockade demands **enormous sustained effort**; a court win can be **reopened**; and the **fragmented, clientelist system** favours connected investors.

A note on cost: organising, holding a blockade, documenting, and litigating cost little money, and the Kruščica women held their bridge with almost no resources but their determination and their allies. The expenditure that most changes outcomes is not money; it is the endurance to hold the ground and the persistence to challenge the permit and draw in the movement — exactly what Kruščica required, at great personal cost.

Effectiveness Visualization



How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in Bosnia are **the physical blockade and the court challenge to a flawed permit**, amplified by **the river-defence movement and international attention**.

Kruščica shows the ceiling: a community held its ground and won in court, and two dams fell. But the honest floor is real too: the blockade took over five hundred days, the win could be reopened, and the fragmented system favours connected investors. Most Bosnian fights sit between, and the honest lesson is that the community's stand, the flawed permit, the courts, and the movement are powerful levers — decisive when a community can hold firm and the permit is defective, weaker when it cannot hold or the permit is sound, where the realistic win is delay, a record, and a partial gain. Read the table, then, as a diagnosis of your own position: a united community that can hold the access route, facing a permit granted without consultation, is in the strong band and can aim to stop the project outright as Kruščica did; a community that cannot sustain a blockade, or that faces a soundly permitted project, is in the weaker band and should aim realistically at delay, a record, and a partial gain while it looks for a flaw. Knowing which band you are in keeps a campaign both ambitious where it can be and realistic where it must be.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **The community's physical stand and organisation** — Bosnia's most distinctive lever; the sustained blockade and united community that held the bridge at Kruščica.
2. **The consultation-defective permit and the court challenge** — the flawed, unconsulted permit and the court case that struck it down, as at Kruščica.
3. **The river-defence movement** — the Blue Heart campaign and its Bosnian partners, bringing expertise, solidarity, and reach.
4. **International attention and media** — the outside solidarity and coverage that amplified a small village's stand and pressured the authorities.
5. **Documentation** — the proof of the harm, the missing consultation, and the flawed permit that grounds every other step.

What Bosnian Campaigns Actually Show

A few patterns recur. **Standing in the way works** — Kruščica physically halted construction while it fought. **Permits are often flawed** — granted without consultation, they can be struck down. **The courts can deliver** — the Novi Travnik court annulled the permits. **The movement and the world amplify** — the Blue Heart campaign and international attention magnified a tiny village's stand. **But the cost is high and the win fragile** — five hundred days, and the investor could return. The through-line: **organise the community; hold the ground where you must; challenge the flawed, unconsulted permit; and draw in the movement and the world — because in Bosnia a community that stands firm and litigates can stop even a connected investor.**

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective campaign begins by finding the exact decision that governs the project — and the leverage the community holds, which in Bosnia is often the flawed permit and the community's ability to stand in the way. Vague opposition goes nowhere; a fight aimed at "the two hydropower permits granted over our river without consulting us" is a campaign — the campaign Kruščica waged. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

1. Which authority granted the permit, and was the community consulted? This is the first Bosnian question. Which **cantonal or entity authority** granted the concession and permit, and was the **community properly consulted** — because a permit granted without consultation is a project's central weakness, as it was at Kruščica. This should be the very first thing a campaign establishes, because in these fights it is so often the decisive fact. The small-hydropower boom moves fast and cuts corners, and the consultation the law requires — genuine, prior, informed engagement with the community whose environment is at stake — is precisely the corner most often cut. A community that can show, with dates and documents, that it was never properly consulted holds the strongest card in the Bosnian deck, the same card that took the Kruščica permits down, so establish early and clearly whether that consultation ever truly happened.

2. Is the permit flawed? Was the **environmental and construction permit** granted on a **sound assessment and lawful process**, or is it defective — the ground a court can strike down? It is worth scrutinising the environmental assessment closely and, where you can, with expert help, because it is both legally required and technically involved, and flaws hide in its detail: a harm to the river's flow understated, an effect on the drinking water ignored, an alternative never considered, a cumulative impact left out. A permit resting on a defective assessment is vulnerable in court in the same

way as one granted without consultation, and a community that reads the assessment carefully, rather than assuming it must be sound because an authority approved it, often finds the very flaw that will undo the project.

3. What does it do to the river, the water, and the community? What **harm** does the project cause — to the river, the drinking water, the land, the community — and what does the community stand to lose, as Kruščica stood to lose its water? The drinking-water dimension is worth drawing out wherever it applies, because it carries a moral and practical force that few arguments match: a project that threatens the very water a community drinks is not an abstract environmental concern but a direct threat to daily life and health, and it unites a community and moves outsiders as little else does. It was the threat to their drinking water that steeled the people of Kruščica to stand on that bridge through everything, and a community whose water is at stake should place that fact at the very centre of its case, to the courts, the public, and the world.

4. Can the community hold the ground and organise? Can the community **stand in the way** if it must, and organise to sustain a long fight, as Kruščica held its bridge?

5. Who decides, who benefits, and who can be drawn in? Which authority and investor are behind it, who profits from the subsidies; and which courts, movement partners, press, and international allies can be engaged.

A Worked Example

Suppose an investor obtains permits for a small hydropower plant on a community's river, granted by a cantonal authority without consulting the village.

Working the five questions: which **authority** granted the permit, and was the community **consulted**? Is the **permit flawed**? What **harm** to the river and water? Can the community **hold the ground**? And the deciders are the authority and the investor, with the courts, the movement, the press, and the international allies as the pressure points.

Within a season you have moved from "they will dam our river" to a target list: document the missing consultation and the harm; challenge the flawed permit; organise the community to hold the ground; and draw in the movement and the world. That is a campaign, not a complaint — and it draws directly on how Kruščica won. Notice what the exercise did: it turned a frightening arrival of machines into a set of concrete, winnable tasks — prove the missing consultation, challenge the permit, organise to hold the ground, draw in the movement — each tied to a specific lever that a small community can actually pull. That reframing, from helplessness to a plan built on the community's real strengths, its unity and its river, is the difference the five questions make in Bosnia, and the first of them, whether the community was consulted, often decides whether there is a legal foothold at all.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on. A court, an authority, a journalist, and the world all move on evidence, not indignation — and in Bosnia, the flawed permit and the missing consultation are precisely what a court can act on, so document them well. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Concession, the Permit, and the Consultation

Get the documents the decision rests on. Obtain the **concession, the environmental permit, and the construction permit** — and establish **whether the community was consulted**, because a permit granted without proper consultation is often a project's fatal flaw, as it was at Kruščica, where the court struck the permits down for exactly that. Scrutinise the **environmental assessment** for gaps and errors. Document the **subsidies** that drive the project, because they reveal who really benefits. The gap between what the law requires — consultation, a sound assessment — and what was done is where many Bosnian cases are won. The consultation failure deserves particular attention, because it proved decisive at Kruščica and is common across these projects. Bosnian and international law entitle a community to be informed and heard before a project affects its environment, and the small-hydropower boom, driven by speed and connection, routinely tramples that entitlement — permits issued with token notice or none, assessments waved through, communities learning of a dam only when the machines arrive. Documenting clearly that the community was never genuinely consulted is therefore not a side issue but often the single strongest legal ground available, the very ground on which the Kruščica permits were annulled.

Layer 2: The Harm to the River and the Water

Document the reality the paper understates, and put the **river and the water** at the centre. Record the **harm** — to the river's flow, the drinking water, the fish, the land, the community — that the project would cause, as Kruščica documented the threat to its drinking water. Document what the community **stands to lose**. Photograph and date it. Record **testimony** from those who depend on the river. This is the human case that unites the community and moves the courts, the nation, and the world.

Layer 3: The Flaw, the Harm, and the Consultation

Finally, document the case. Was there **no proper consultation**? Is the **permit flawed** — a defective assessment, an unlawful process? Is the **harm** to the river and water real and grave? Each is a separate ground — for the courts, the campaign, and the movement — and together they make a case that is hard to wave away. This is the layer that most often decides Bosnian fights, because here a project sold as lawful is revealed to rest on an unconsulted, flawed permit and to threaten the community's river and water — exactly the case that struck down the Kruščica dams. The strength of assembling all three grounds together — the missing consultation, the flawed permit, and the harm — is that they serve different fronts and reinforce one another: the missing consultation and the flawed permit are the legal core a court can act on, while the harm to the river and the drinking water is what unites the community and moves the public and the world. A community that documents only the harm may have a moving cause but a weak case; one that documents only the legal flaw may win a ruling without the public behind it; the campaigns that prevail in Bosnia, as Kruščica did, build all three and press them together.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

This is the practical companion to Step 2: the specific records that decide Bosnian cases, and where to obtain them. You will not need every item; you will need the few that establish the missing consultation, the flawed permit, and the harm.

The Permit, the Consultation, and the Paper Trail

- **The concession and the permits** — how the project was authorised, and by which cantonal or entity authority.
- **The consultation record** — whether the community was properly consulted, the central legal question.
- **The environmental assessment** — the study behind the permit, and often the most vulnerable to challenge.
- **The subsidies** — the feed-in support that drives the project and reveals who benefits.
- **The investor** — who is behind the project, and their backing.

How to Get Them

The permits, concessions, and assessments are matters of record, obtainable from the granting authority and through freedom-of-information requests; the consultation record through the same and the community's own account; the subsidies through the energy regulator and public data. Lean on **allies**: the **river-defence movement** — the Blue Heart campaign and its Bosnian partner organisations — which know the permits, the law, and the pattern of the small-hydropower boom; local environmental lawyers; and the international networks that supported Kruščica. Move promptly: obtaining the permit and proving the missing consultation early lets you challenge it before construction, and lets you draw in the movement and the world while the fight is fresh, as Kruščica drew them in from the start. The timing here is a real strategic matter and repays acting on early: environmental information and the permit are most useful obtained while the decision is fresh and construction has not begun, because a permit is far easier to challenge and a river far easier to save before the machines have done their damage. Kruščica's villagers moved the moment the machines appeared, taking the fight to the bridge and the courts at once rather than waiting to see what would happen; a community that acts quickly to secure the documents, prove the missing consultation, and summon its allies while the ground is still whole gives itself by far the best chance.

The Ground Evidence

- **The harm** — to the river, the drinking water, the fish, the land, dated and documented.
- **The missing consultation** — proof the community was not properly asked.
- **The flawed permit** — the gaps in the assessment, the unlawful steps.
- **The subsidies and the beneficiaries** — who profits from the project.
- **Testimony** — from those who depend on the river and the water.

Organise It So It Persuades

Keep a **master timeline** of the concession, the permit, the consultation, the harm, and every step of the fight — the spine of any court case or campaign. Keep a **document index** so any fact can be sourced in seconds. And keep an **argument bank** (developed in a later section) that pairs each fact with what it proves, to whom. A well-ordered file is not bureaucracy; it is what lets a villager, a lawyer, a journalist, a judge, and an international ally all see the same clear picture fast, and it guards against the campaign's own worst enemy, a claim that cannot be sourced when the investor or the authority pushes back. In a country where the courts respond to a flawed permit and a missing consultation, the community with the better-kept file — above all the clearest proof that it was not consulted — is very often the one that wins, as Kruščica won.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION — HOW TO ORGANISE THE COMMUNITY AND HOLD THE GROUND

Evidence and permits do not win on their own. Organised people do — and in Bosnia, the Brave Women of Kruščica proved that a determined community, standing physically in the way, can stop a project while it fights it in court. A campaign's strength here is that community: united, enduring, and, where it must be, immovable.

Phase 1: The Core and the Community

Start with a committed core rooted in the **whole affected community**, because in Bosnia the community's stand is the decisive lever. Assign roles — documentation, legal liaison, the organisation of the blockade or the watch, media, and movement and international liaison. Agree on the goal — the permit quashed, the project stopped, the river held — and on what the community will and will not accept. Draw on the community's own strength: at Kruščica, the women led and the whole village sustained the watch, sharing the burden so no one carried it alone. This shared organisation was not incidental to the Kruščica victory but central to it, and it is the practical answer to the obvious question of how ordinary people sustain a stand for five hundred days. By spreading the watch across the whole community — women through the day, men through the night, neighbours summoned when needed — the village turned an impossible individual burden into a manageable collective one, and made itself impossible to defeat by targeting a single leader. A community planning such a stand should build that breadth of participation in from the beginning, because a fight that rests on a few will exhaust them, while one shared by many can endure.

Phase 2: The Broad Coalition

Then widen deliberately. Bring in the **whole village and the neighbouring communities**, so the affected area stands as one; the **river-defence movement** — the Blue Heart campaign and its Bosnian partner organisations — which bring expertise, legal support, and solidarity; **environmental lawyers**; the **independent press**; and the **international networks and media** that can amplify a small community's stand, as they amplified Kruščica's, all the way to the European Parliament and a documentary seen around the world. The Kruščica fight drew its power from exactly this breadth — a united village, a regional movement, and international attention — which is precisely the spread a winning Bosnian campaign needs. The international dimension of that coalition deserves emphasis, because for a small and poor community it can be transformative. Kruščica was not left to fight alone: a coordinated regional campaign to protect the Balkans' rivers brought legal expertise, funding, and a network of allies, and an international audience — reached through a widely screened documentary and coverage across Europe — turned a local dispute into a cause that authorities could not quietly ignore. A Bosnian community should reach deliberately for that wider movement and that outside attention early, because they supply exactly what a village on its own lacks: expertise, resources, and a spotlight.

A worked coalition example. Facing a hydropower permit, the village forms the base and holds the ground; the river-defence movement brings the expertise and the legal case; the lawyers challenge the permit; and the international networks and press amplify the stand. No single group could carry it; together they cover the ground, the law, and the world — the model Kruščica built. What is worth drawing from that model is how each element supplied what the others could not: the villagers brought the moral standing and the physical presence that only those whose water is threatened can bring; the river-defence movement brought the legal expertise and the hard-won knowledge of how these permits fail; and the international networks and press brought the spotlight that a small village could never light on its own. A community beginning a fight should honestly assess which of these it already has and which it must recruit, because it is the completeness of the coalition, not the passion of any single part, that has repeatedly proved decisive in these river battles.

Phase 3: Sustaining It

Campaigns die of burnout — and a Bosnian fight can mean holding a blockade for many months through hardship, as

Kruščica held its bridge for over five hundred days through police violence and icy winters. Organise the **watch in shifts**, so the burden is shared and no one is broken by it, as Kruščica shared it. Meet on a rhythm. Give people concrete tasks. Mark small wins — the permit obtained, the missing consultation proven, a court filing, a wave of coverage, an international ally won. Keep the community united and the burden shared, and guard against the **division, the threats, and the exhaustion** — the pressure from the investor and the authorities, the wearing-down of a long watch — that will be used to break the community. Expect these pressures, because they are the standard response to a community that cannot be quickly cleared: an offer of money or jobs to some families but not others, a rumour set loose to turn neighbours against the leaders, a threat to those with something to lose, and always the simple attrition of a watch that must be kept night after night through every season. The defences are unity and transparency — keeping every part of the community informed and involved, insisting that no private deal be struck that abandons the common cause, and sharing the burden so widely that no one is worn past breaking — the same defences that carried Kruščica through more than five hundred days.

Phase 4: Holding the Ground

Here is Bosnia's distinctive strength. Where a project cannot be stopped fast enough by the courts alone, a community can **stand physically in the way** — as Kruščica blockaded the bridge to the construction site, halting the machines while the legal fight proceeded. Organise the **blockade or the watch** with discipline: keep it **peaceful**, share the shifts, document everything, and know your rights, because the authorities may send police, as they sent riot police to Kruščica, and a disciplined, peaceful, well-documented stand keeps the community's legitimacy and the public's sympathy when force is used against it. The Kruščica experience proves the point in the starkest way: when riot police cleared peaceful villagers from the bridge by force, injuring women who had done nothing but stand in the way, it was the authorities who lost in the eyes of the public and the world, and the images of that day became part of what drew international sympathy to the village's cause. That outcome depended entirely on the villagers' own restraint — had they met force with force, the story would have been theirs to answer for. A community that holds the ground must therefore hold it peacefully and document everything, so that any violence used against it rebounds on those who use it. The point is not confrontation for its own sake; it is to hold the ground — to keep the machines out — while the court challenge, the movement, and the world's attention do their work, as they did at Kruščica. Understand that this is a hard, demanding, sometimes dangerous course, to be entered with broad support, open eyes, and care for the people who hold the line. A few practical principles make such a stand sustainable rather than a brief, exhausting flare. Organise it as a rota, so that watching the bridge is a shared duty spread across the whole community rather than a burden borne by a heroic few; build a shelter and lay in supplies for the long haul and the hard weather, as Kruščica did with its hut beside the bridge; keep a phone tree or signal so that the community can be summoned quickly when the machines appear, as the villagers summoned two hundred neighbours to turn the excavators back; and document every encounter, especially any use of force, because that record protects the community legally and moves the public morally. A stand planned for endurance can hold; one improvised in anger rarely lasts.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES — THE PERMIT, THE CONSULTATION, AND THE COURTS

Bosnia's courts, for all the system's weaknesses, can and do annul flawed permits — as the Novi Travnik court did for Kruščica — and the legal challenge, run alongside the blockade, is often what turns a community's stand into a lasting win. You do not need a fast victory to win: a permit quashed, a consultation failure established, or a project delayed while you hold the ground can each be a real victory. Engage lawyers and the movement early — but understand the tools.

The Consultation and the Permit

The first and most distinctive lever is the **consultation and the permit**. Bosnia's small-hydropower permits are frequently granted **without the community consultation the law requires**, and on **flawed environmental assessments** — and a court can **annul a permit** on exactly those grounds, as the Kruščica permits were struck down for the lack of proper consultation. Establish the missing consultation and the permit's flaws, and mount the challenge; this is the ground on which many Bosnian dam fights are won.

The Courts

The second lever is the **courts** themselves. Bosnia's **cantonal, entity, and higher courts** review the legality of permits and decisions, and, as Kruščica showed, they will **quash a permit** that was unlawfully granted. Use the courts to annul the flawed permit, to enforce the consultation requirement, and to defend the river and the community. The legal

challenge, run in parallel with the blockade, is what converts a physical stand into a durable legal victory. It is worth understanding why the two must run together rather than one after the other. A community that blockades but does not litigate may hold the ground heroically only to find, when exhaustion or a court order finally clears the bridge, that the permit still stands and the machines simply return; a community that litigates but does not hold the ground may win a ruling too late, over a river already dug up. Kruščica succeeded because it did both at once — the bridge kept the machines out through the months the case took, and the case turned that hard-won time into a permanent bar on the dams.

Vigilance and Re-Application

The third lever, and one Bosnia's own experience demands, is **vigilance against re-application**. A permit quashed for a flaw can sometimes be **reapplied for** once the flaw is cured, so a court win is often not the end — the Kruščica community stayed on the bridge and watchful even after early victories, knowing the investor might return. Treat a court win as a crucial step, not a final one, and keep the community, the movement, and the legal watch ready to challenge any renewed attempt. This is why the Kruščica community, even after winning in court, did not simply disband and go home but kept its organisation and its watchfulness intact, understanding that a determined investor with a subsidy still to harvest may cure the defect and apply afresh. A community should therefore treat the structures it built for the fight — the rota, the legal contacts, the movement ties, the phone tree — as assets to be maintained rather than dismantled the moment a win is announced, so that any renewed attempt meets a community already organised rather than one that must start over.

Where to Turn and With Whom

Permit and consultation challenges go through the **cantonal and higher courts**; the legality of the process through the same; and the guard against re-application through **continued vigilance and the movement**. Get help early: Bosnia's environmental lawyers and the river-defence movement — the Blue Heart partners — know the permits, the law, and the routes, and their support was central to Kruščica's win. A community should reach for this legal and movement support at the very start, not as a last resort, because the earliest decisions — which permit to challenge, on what ground, within what deadline — often determine whether a case can be won at all, and because the river-defence organisations have fought these exact battles many times before and know the pattern of the boom, the weaknesses of the permits, and the courts that will hear the case. The expertise that took years to accumulate across many Balkan river fights is available to a new campaign that asks for it, and it can spare a community the costliest early mistakes. Help engaged early — before construction, and alongside the blockade — is worth far more than help sought after, and in Bosnia the strongest strategy marries the **community's physical stand** to the **court challenge to the flawed permit**, with the **movement and international attention** amplifying both.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

You have a file of evidence. Now you must turn it into arguments — because the same fact persuades a court, an authority, a journalist, the movement, and an international audience in different ways. Learning to translate your evidence for each audience is what lets a community reach every lever at once.

One Fact, Many Arguments

Take a single documented fact — say, that a permit was granted for two hydropower plants on a village's drinking-water river without ever consulting the community, on an assessment that ignored the harm to the water. That one fact becomes:

- **A legal argument:** the permit was granted without the required consultation and can be annulled — the case before the courts, as at Kruščica.
- **A consultation argument:** the community's right to be consulted was denied — a ground the courts recognise.
- **A public argument:** they are damming our drinking water and never asked us — the case that unites the community and the nation.
- **A subsidy argument:** this project exists to harvest subsidies for a connected investor, not to serve us — the case that exposes the real motive.
- **An international argument:** another of Europe's last wild rivers is threatened by the dam boom — the case that draws the movement and the world.

Same fact, five arguments, five audiences. Go through your strongest facts and, for each, ask what it proves to each audience. That table is your campaign's argument bank — and in Bosnia the arguments that most often decide things are

the **missing-consultation** one, because it wins in court, and the **our-water** one, because it unites the community and moves the world. Keep the arguments anchored to the same documented facts, so a claim made to a reporter can be backed in the permit record and a claim made to a judge can be proven by the consultation facts; consistency across audiences is itself persuasive.

Match the Argument to the Audience

The courts want the missing consultation and the permit's flaws framed against the law, with the records that prove them.

The authorities respond to the legal risk of a quashed permit and to the weight of public and international attention.

Journalists need a specific, vivid story with a hook: villagers, women in the lead, guarding a bridge day and night to save their drinking water.

The public needs the argument simple and true: our river, our drinking water, dammed without our consent for someone's profit.

The river-defence movement and international allies respond to the threat to Europe's last wild rivers and to a community standing firm against the dam boom.

The community itself needs to see the permit is beatable and the stand is worth it, so it holds the ground, as Kruščica held it for five hundred days.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY — HOW COVERAGE SHIFTS OUTCOMES

Media is not vanity; it is a lever — and for a small Bosnian community, international attention can be the difference, amplifying a village's stand and pressuring authorities who would ignore it. The Kruščica community itself credited the international attention with increasing the pressure that helped win their court case; their stand became part of a documentary seen around the world and screened in the European Parliament. Coverage draws in the movement, the world, and the pressure.

Build the Story

Reporters and the public need specifics: a named place, a documented wrong, and a human and natural stake. "A community opposes a dam" is not a story; "villagers, women in the lead, guarded a bridge day and night for over five hundred days to stop two dams on their drinking-water river, granted without their consent" is — the story that carried Kruščica to the world. Lead with your strongest verified facts — the missing consultation, the threat to the water, the stand — and offer a human voice: a woman of the blockade, a villager, an elder. In Bosnia the story of a small community standing firm to defend its river against a connected investor is one that resonates at home and abroad.

Reach the Right Outlets

Work outward in rings. **Local and community voices** first. Then the **national outlets** — because a community's river is a national story. Then, crucially, the **international and movement ring** — the Blue Heart campaign, the international environmental press and networks — because for a small Bosnian village, international attention amplifies the stand and applies the pressure that domestic outlets alone cannot. Feed each ring what it needs, and let coverage in one pull in the next. The **international and movement ring is especially powerful** in Bosnia, because it magnifies a small community's fight and reaches authorities who respond to their international reputation.

Sustain It, and Keep It True

A single article changes little; a drumbeat changes decisions — and a Bosnian fight can run through a long blockade and a longer court case. Plan a sequence — the permit, the missing consultation, the blockade, the police, the court win — so there is always a next hook, and build your own clear record so the story reaches the nation and the world and endures. Keep messaging disciplined, accurate, and consistent; the investor and the authorities will seize on any exaggeration, and a peaceful, dignified stand tells its own powerful story, as the image of women guarding a bridge told Kruščica's. Verified, specific, river-and-consent-centred, and carried to the world — that is the coverage that shifts outcomes here, and that helped a village stop two dams.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Written communications are how you request, object, create a record, and reach the bodies that can act — the authorities, the investors, the courts, and the movement and press. Each does double duty: it asks for something and it documents that you asked. Keep copies of everything, and send important items so that receipt is provable. Below are adaptable templates for the situations you will meet most often. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the consultation, the permit, and the harm.

8A. Request for the Permit and Consultation Record

To: the cantonal / entity authority **Subject:** Request for the permit and consultation records for [project]

We, [community/organisation], request the **concession, the environmental and construction permits, the environmental assessment, and the consultation record** for [project] on the [river]. We require these to assess the project's lawfulness, and we note that the community was [not consulted / inadequately consulted], contrary to law. Please provide the documents within the statutory period.

8B. Objection and Assertion of the Consultation Failure

To: the permitting authority **Subject:** Objection to [project] — no community consultation

We, the community of [village], object to [project]. The permit was granted **without the community consultation the law requires**, on an environmental assessment that **understated the harm** to our river and drinking water. We demand that the permit be **withdrawn or annulled**, and we reserve our right to challenge it before the courts, as the community of Kruščica successfully did.

8C. Court Challenge (with a Lawyer)

To: the cantonal court (via counsel) **Subject:** Challenge to the permit for [project]

On behalf of [community/organisation], we challenge the permit for [project] as **unlawful**, granted **without the required consultation** and on a **flawed environmental assessment**. We seek its **annulment** and the halting of construction, and attach the record demonstrating the missing consultation and the flaws, as established in the Kruščica precedent.

8D. Letter to the Investor

To: the investor **Subject:** The community's opposition to [project]

We write regarding [project] on the [river]. The community opposes it: it threatens our drinking water, it was permitted without consulting us, and it serves [subsidies and profit] rather than the community. We call on you to **abandon** the project, and we advise that the community will hold the ground, challenge the permit, and draw the movement and the world to its defence, as Kruščica did.

8E. Instructing a Lawyer / Movement Partner

To: an environmental lawyer / a river-defence organisation **Subject:** [Project] — the permit, the consultation, and the challenge

We are defending the [river] from [project]. We attach the permits, the consultation record, and our evidence of harm, and seek advice on **challenging the permit for the lack of consultation, enforcing our rights**, and **guarding against re-application**. Please advise on the strongest ground and the deadlines.

8F. Appeal to the River-Defence Movement / International Networks

To: the Blue Heart campaign / a river-defence organisation **Subject:** Support for [village]'s defence of the [river]

We write regarding [project], which threatens our [river] and drinking water, part of the wider dam boom across our rivers. As the movement supported the Brave Women of Kruščica, we ask for your **expertise, legal support, and solidarity**, and for the **international attention** that can amplify our stand. We attach our case and can host you at our river.

8G. Email to a Reporter (National or International)

To: [journalist] **Subject:** Story tip: [specific finding] — [the river / the village]

I follow your coverage of [beat]. We have something worth telling, with a clear hook: [documents and testimony] show [quantified finding — e.g. "a village, women in the lead, has guarded a bridge day and night for months to stop two dams on its drinking-water river, permitted without its consent"]. It echoes Kruščica. I can share the file and connect you with a woman of the blockade. Could we talk this week?

8H. Public / Community Statement

To: the public and the authorities **Subject:** We defend the [river]

We, the community of [village], declare that we will defend our [river] and our drinking water. [Project] would dam our water, it was permitted without our consent, and it serves profit, not us. As the Brave Women of Kruščica held their bridge and won, we will hold our ground, challenge the permit in the courts, and call on the movement and the world, and we will not relent until our river is safe.

Using the Templates Well

Send important communications so that receipt is provable, and log every one in your timeline — the record of a request, an objection, or a challenge is itself evidence, and exactly what the courts, the authorities, and the world will heed. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the consultation, the permit, and the harm; attach your evidence; and route them, where you can, through the community, the movement, your lawyers, and the press. The reply, or the ruling, becomes part of your record, and in Bosnia that record feeds the levers that matter most: the court challenge to the flawed permit, the community's stand, and the movement and international attention that amplify both.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Not everyone can run a long campaign or hold a bridge for five hundred days. With a few hours a week you can still do real damage to a bad project. In rough order of impact for the effort:

- 1. Get the permit and prove the missing consultation.** Obtain the permit and consultation record and establish that the community was not properly consulted (Step 2, 8A).
- 2. Object on the consultation failure.** Put the objection and the consultation failure on the record (8B).
- 3. Reach the river-defence movement.** Connect with the Blue Heart campaign and its Bosnian partners for expertise and support (8F).
- 4. Challenge the permit.** With a lawyer, challenge the flawed, unconsulted permit in court (8C, 8E).
- 5. Organise the community.** Build the community's unity and readiness to act (Step 3).
- 6. Draw in the world.** Reach the press and international networks (8G).
- 7. Hold the ground only if you must, and together.** As a last resort, and with broad support and shared shifts, stand in the way — but understand the cost (Step 3).

Do only the first three and you will have proven the missing consultation, put it on the record, and drawn in the movement — the foundation of a Bosnian river defence. Then come back and read the rest. Even the shortest version has a spine: prove the missing consultation, object, bring in the movement.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Bosnia's system is tilted in specific ways you must understand, so you neither waste effort nor miss the levers that work.

Where the Tilt Shows

The tilt here is real and rooted in the country's structure. Power is **fragmented** among entities, cantons, and districts, so responsibility is diffuse and an authority can hide behind another. The **small-hydropower boom** is driven by **subsidies** that make even damaging projects profitable, so investors are persistent and often **connected** to those who grant the permits. **Institutions are weak**, and **clientelism** shapes who gets a concession. And **permits are granted with little consultation**, treating the community as an afterthought. Where these tilts bite, a campaign that assumes the authorities will protect the community, or that a single objection will stop a subsidised project, will be disappointed.

What Still Works — And Some Is Distinctive

The decisive point is that even against this tilt, real levers remain.

The community can still stand in the way. No fragmented system can move a community that physically holds the ground, as Kruščica held its bridge.

The permit is still often flawed. The very haste and clientelism that grant a permit without consultation create the flaw a court can strike down.

The courts still deliver. As Kruščica showed, Bosnia's courts will annul a permit granted without proper consultation.

The movement still amplifies. The Blue Heart campaign and its partners bring expertise, solidarity, and reach that a lone village lacks.

The world still watches. International attention magnifies a small community's stand and pressures authorities who value their reputation.

The Honest Frame

So the honest frame for Bosnia is realistic but far from hopeless: the system is fragmented, clientelist, and tilted toward subsidised investors, but the community's stand, the flawed permit, the courts, and the movement give a determined community real levers. So diagnose your fight honestly: prove the **missing consultation** and the **flawed permit**; organise the **community** and, where you must, **hold the ground**; **challenge the permit** in court; and draw in the **movement and the world** — while understanding that the stand may demand great endurance and the win may need guarding against a fresh application. Do not assume the tilted system will protect you; the Kruščica win came because the community stood firm, litigated, and drew in the world, not because the system worked on its own.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

Bosnia has real and well-documented concerns about how concessions and permits are granted, so this section matters. When a permit is granted not in the public interest but because an investor is connected, or a subsidy is there to be harvested, or an official benefits, your strategy includes exposing that.

How to Tell

Look for the signatures of capture. A **permit granted without consultation** and against the community's clear interest; a **subsidy** that makes a damaging project profitable for a connected investor; a **concession** awarded opaquely or to the well-connected; **officials who benefit** from the arrangement; and a project that **serves select individuals** while the community bears the harm — exactly the critique the Kruščica campaigners made. Trace the permit and the money: who granted it, who profits from the subsidies, whether the community was ever genuinely consulted. In Bosnia, a small-hydropower permit that dams a village's water without its consent is often not a mere oversight but an arrangement that serves the connected.

Who Can Be Captured — and Who Is Harder

Be clear-eyed about where capture reaches. **Parts of the cantonal and entity administration, and the officials who grant concessions**, can be captured by connected investors and the subsidy money. But some forces are far harder to capture, and they are your targets: the **courts**, which do annul flawed permits; the **river-defence movement** and its international partners; the **independent press**; the **international organisations** watching Bosnia's governance; and the **community** itself, which holds the ground. Capture thrives on the community's silence and isolation; your task is to unite the community, document the capture and the missing consultation, and bring it to the courts, the movement, and

the world.

What to Do

Do not assume a captured permit cannot be undone. Instead, **document the capture precisely** — how the permit was granted, without what consultation, who profits from the subsidies — and take it to the forces that can act: the **courts**, to annul the flawed permit; the **river-defence movement**, for expertise and solidarity; the **independent press and international networks**, to expose it; and the **community's stand**, to hold the ground meanwhile. Pair the exposure with the legal challenge and the blockade, so the impropriety and the pressure arrive together. In Bosnia, exposing how a permit was captured by a connected investor, and proving the community was never consulted, is often the way to strike it down — as the Kruščica community struck down the dams that would have taken their water. There is a wider significance to winning such a case that a community should hold onto through the hard days: every permit exposed and annulled for a missing consultation not only saves one river but strengthens the principle that protects them all, warning investors and officials that a permit pushed through without consulting the community can be undone, and showing the next village that the boom is not unstoppable. Kruščica became exactly such a beacon for river defenders across the country, and a community that fights and wins joins and extends that chain of precedent, defending not only its own water but the rivers of communities it will never meet.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The five steps win when they run together. Here is how they fit across the life of a fight — which in Bosnia turns on the community's stand and the court challenge to the flawed permit.

Early (Weeks 0-12): The Permit, the Consultation, and the Community

Pin down the project and the granting authority (Step 1); obtain the **permit** and document the **missing consultation** and the harm (Step 2). Unite the **community** and prepare to hold the ground if needed (Step 3). Move at once on what is decisive: **request the records** (8A); **object on the consultation failure** (8B); reach a **lawyer and the river-defence movement** early (8E, 8F); and prepare the **court challenge** (8C). This phase lays the foundation, and in Bosnia the proven missing consultation and the united community established here are what win.

Middle (Months 2-24): Hold, Challenge, and Amplify

Sustain the community and, where needed, the **blockade or watch**, sharing the burden (Step 3). Turn your evidence into arguments for each audience (Turning Evidence). Mount the **court challenge** to the flawed permit (Step 4). Build the media drumbeat from local to national to international, drawing in the **movement and the world** (Step 5). Each front feeds the others. Do the time-critical things first — holding the ground and challenging the permit before construction — because those chances do not return.

Later (Months 6-36+): The Ruling, and Vigilance

Pursue the decisive outcome — the **permit quashed, the project stopped, the river held** — and then guard it, because, as at Kruščica, the investor may **reapply**, and the community must stay ready. Judge success honestly. Sometimes it is a project stopped outright, as at Kruščica. Sometimes it is a permit quashed, a project delayed, and a river defended for now, needing continued watch. Both are victories worth the fight. And even a partial win compounds in a country where the boom is far from over: a project delayed may lose its financing or its political cover, a permit quashed sets a precedent the next investor must reckon with, and a record built in one river's defence arms the community that takes up the next. A campaign should value what it can win now, not only for its own river but for the way each proven consultation failure and each quashed permit strengthens the wider movement that saved Kruščica's water.

The Shape of a Campaign

WEEKS 0-12	Get the permit + prove missing consultation Unite the community Object Reach lawyer + movement
MONTHS 2-24	Hold the ground (if needed) Court challenge Amplify with movement + world Media
MONTHS 6-36+	Permit quashed / project stopped / river held Guard against re-application

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Bosnia gives communities a genuinely powerful — and distinctive — set of tools, and the honest measure of this guide is how squarely it faces both their strength and their limits.

The strengths are real and distinctive. A community that **stands physically in the way** can halt a project while it fights, as Kruščica held its bridge. The **consultation-defective permit** is a real legal weakness a **court can strike down**, as the Novi Travnik court struck down the Kruščica dams. The **river-defence movement** — the Blue Heart campaign and its partners — brings expertise, solidarity, and reach. And **international attention** can amplify a small village's stand and pressure the authorities. These are the tools that let a tiny community stop two dams and hold its river. They are, notably, tools that depend on unity, endurance, and a flawed permit rather than on wealth or power, which is why they were available to a poor village against a connected investor — and why, used with the same determination, they remain available to communities across a country where the dam boom is far from over.

The limits are just as real, and this guide names them. The Kruščica win took a **staggering, sustained sacrifice** — five hundred days and nights, police violence, injuries, arrests. The court victory could be **reopened** by a fresh application. And Bosnia's **fragmented, clientelist system** favours subsidised, connected investors. No guide should pretend these away; in Bosnia, the art is to stand firm where you must, to win in court on the flawed permit, to draw in the movement and the world, and to keep watch even after a win.

So the realistic promise is this: **prove the missing consultation and the flawed permit; organise the community and hold the ground where you must; challenge the permit in the courts; draw in the movement and the world; and guard the win against re-application — running all of it together.** Do that, and where a community can stand firm and the permit is flawed, you can quash the permit and stop the project, as Kruščica did; where you cannot hold the ground, you can still win delay, a record, and a partial gain. Do it as the Brave Women of Kruščica did — a village that stood on a bridge, took the permits to court, drew the world to its river, and won.

A last word on standing firm. Bosnia's lesson is that a determined community holds more power than a fragmented, tilted system wants it to believe — that women in a small village, standing on a bridge day and night, can stop two dams backed by a connected investor — but that the power is bought with endurance and must be guarded even after it is won. The powerful count on your resignation, your exhaustion, and your isolation. Their advantage is the subsidy, the connected permit, and the wearing-down of a long watch. Yours is a community that can stand in the way, a permit flawed by the very haste that granted it, courts that will strike it down, a movement that will stand with you, and a world that will watch — and the proven fact that the Brave Women of Kruščica held their bridge for five hundred days and won. Play to that. Keep the record and the proof of the missing consultation, keep the community united and the burden shared, hold the ground and challenge the permit, draw in the movement and the world, and treat every day the ground is held, every filing, and every quashed permit as a stone in a dam of your own that no investor can easily breach.

The tools are here, and Bosnia itself proved them: a small village, women in the lead, that stood on a bridge for more than five hundred days and nights, took the flawed permits to court, drew the world to its little river, and stopped two dams that would have taken its drinking water. What decides the outcome, in the end, is the community's unity and endurance, the flawed permit, the courts, the movement, and the world's attention — and those a determined community can summon. Begin today, begin with the permit and the proof that you were never consulted, and build from there. Communities before you have held their ground and saved their rivers — a bridge held, a permit quashed, a river defended. They did it with unity, endurance, and the full use of the levers around them, against investors who were connected and a system that was tilted, and often at real cost to themselves — which is exactly why your own community's stand, added to theirs, is neither hopeless nor unimportant. What the women of Kruščica won can be won again. So can yours. A village that put its bodies on a bridge and its case before a court, and would not yield through five hundred days and nights of cold and fear and force, has shown what an ordinary community can do against money and connections when it refuses to move; the stand, the flawed permit, the courts, the movement, and the world are the method, and the proof that even a tiny community can win is now yours to take up and use.